with Rahul Gandhi in the fourteen days the Yatra was supposed to be in Maharashtra. Given our general apathy towards the Congress party's organization, we were pleasantly surprised to find many dynamic, idealistic and sharp Congressmen actively working with us shoulder to shoulder. They took great pains to take everyone along (which, given civil society's general disparateness, was an extremely difficult job to achieve). At the behest of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge for Maharashtra H.K. Patil (who Dr Ganesh Devy shared a great personal equation with and minutely discussed our preparations with every step of the way), Balasaheb Thorat and Mohan Joshi deputed Hussain Dalwai, Kumar Ketkar and Pushparaj Deshpande to collaborate with us. After a careful study of Maharashtra's key socio-economic and political situation, we consensually narrowed down to the following issues (and groups)—organized and unorganized labour; displacement and migration; minority welfare; the subaltern traditions of Maharashtra; women and LGBT welfare; denotified and nomadic tribes; Adivasi issues; farmers' issues; health; education; Dalit welfare; OBC welfare; and youth welfare. Each group brought together about ten to fifteen key stakeholders with extensive networks across the state. Each of these groups individually prepared a comprehensive compilation of the most pressing issues facing each sector. They were able to also mobilize more than 200 organizations and movements across the state. This kind of preparatory work and mobilization was unprecedented. But by the time the Yatra entered Maharashtra, we were all raring to go.

Late on 7 November (the day of Tripurari Pournima, or the full moon in the lunar month of Kartik, which is considered to be an especially auspicious moment in Hinduism), Rahul Gandhi and his fellow yatris entered Deglur (in Nanded, Maharashtra) carrying torches. The visual of this dramatic entry at night (at that particular auspicious moment), combined with a night-time commemorative visit to Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj's statue and to Guru Gobind Singh's final resting place, was electrifying in Maharashtra, which is a deeply spiritual and emotional state. It sent a powerful message across every hearth in the state. Even though the